finance. Did this indicate a tussle between the prime minister and the finance minister? Did this suggest that the prime minister uncharacteristically pushed for my extension overruling the finance minister's reservations? If indeed Pranab Mukherjee was against an extension for me, wouldn't that impair the already fraught relationship between the two of us?

I am no wiser than anyone else on the first question of whether the prime minister prevailed over the finance minister's opposition, but if it were true, it would have marked another turnaround. Recall that I wrote earlier about how Chidambaram may not have been inclined to take me in as finance secretary in 2007 but the prime minister had nudged him; and later in 2008, it was Chidambaram who reportedly backed my candidature for the governor's job even as the prime minister was not too sure. And now it was a case of the prime minister backing me against Pranab Mukherjee's wishes. But all this is surely in the realm of speculation.

On the second question, I must say that my relationship with Pranab Mukherjee remained exactly as before. He continued to be friendly and gracious, just as before, and he continued to be upset with my interest-rate policies just as before.

The media and the financial sector endorsed the decision. The *Economic Times* wrote that a fresh two-year term for Subbarao was a 'reflection of the confidence in the way he has handled the monetary policy and also signalling continuity at a time of turmoil in global markets'. In an editorial titled, 'Mr. Crisis', the *Financial Express*, while endorsing the extension, said that 'few RBI chiefs have handled two crises like Subbarao'. The *Mint* hailed the government's decision and complimented me for coming into my own as a central banker. 'The July policy,' it wrote, 'demonstrated that Subbarao had graduated from being a Finance Secretary sent to the RBI to take up the Government's job, to being a central banker.'

Those endorsements came with plenty of advice too. Analysts, asked for their opinion by the media, said that I must move away from my 'baby-step' rate action to a more aggressive interest rate-setting policy, that I must improve my communication 'to convince households and markets that my